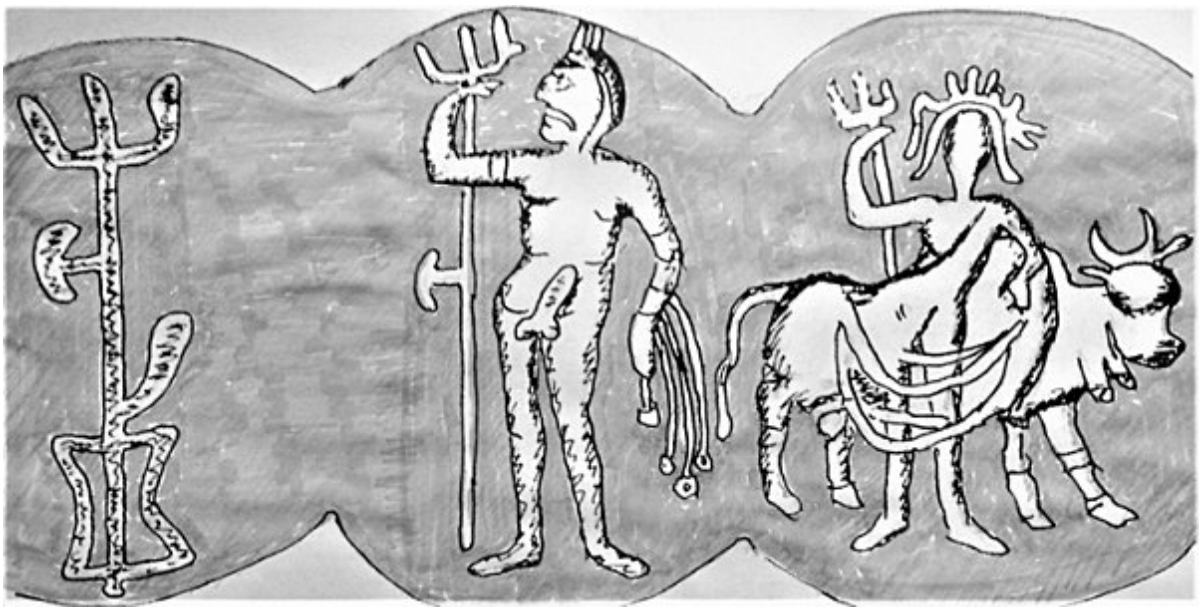


Oesho/Shiva as he appears on three coins of the Kushan ruler Vima Kadphises, first in aniconic form as a phallic trident, then in human form with trident, and finally with his bull Nandi.

This quite extraordinary carving, breathtaking in its vigour and sharpness of detail, may well be the earliest known sculpture in stone that can be linked indisputably with Shaivism, and on that score alone it is hugely important. Just about every historian of Indian art has had his or her say on its dating, beginning with its discoverer in 1903, the archaeologist and epigraphist T. A. Gopinatha Rao, who headed Travancore State's Archaeological Department until his early death in 1919. Rao believed it to date from the third or second century BCE but was promptly challenged by many of his contemporaries, with Ananda Coomaraswamy assigning it to the seventh century CE and Dr Bhandarkar to the early Gupta era, so fourth century. In 1994 Karthikeya Sharma, director of the ASI, excavated the base of the statue and found evidence that led him to ascribe it to the third–second centuries BCE. More recently still, the art historian and epigraphist Calambur Sivaramamurthi, long associated with Chennai Museum, saw close affinities with